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ROLE OF GREEN FINANCE IN PROMOTING SUSTAINABLE BANKING PRACTICES IN INDIA

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ABSTRACT:

Green Finance refers to one of the most popular approaches towards facilitating sustainable development through ESG criteria incorporation into financial management. This research paper discusses about the role of green finance in sustainable banking in India. The major focus is on the awareness, perception, impact, and problems associated with it. Primary and secondary data is used for the research. Secondary sources included reports, journals, and regulations, while primary data was collected through questionnaires shared with 112 bank employees from different banks. According to the survey, the most of the participants were aware of green finance and its advantages in promoting sustainable banking. Green finance may support banks handle environmental risks while improving their performance and image. The responses from the participants show that banks face some challenges while implementing green finance practices. The major challenges include the limited technical skills, low customer awareness, high implementation cost, and low investment in green projects. The research reveals a positive correlation between awareness of green finance and sustainable banking. The study indicates that while there are several opportunities for green finance in the Indian banking sector, but still efforts are required in terms of increasing awareness and training in this regard.

KEYWORDS : Green Finance, Sustainable Banking, Green Banking Practices, Renewable Energy Financing, ESG

INTRODUCTION

Sustainability has been given importance in the finance industry due to the increasing awareness of sustainable development in today's world. The environmental factor have become important in financing. The role of green finance is helpful in promoting investments in eco-friendly technologies, sustainable development projects, and waste handling systems (United Nations Environment Programme, 2021). Also through green finance we see investment in which goes to green projects that in turn play a role in making the economy low carbon and at the same time increase the resilience of the economy to climate change. As we see an increase in climate change issues which include global warming, extreme weather events, and resource depletion banks must adopt practices of sustainable banking. Because of this, banks are starting to include environmental, social, and governance (ESG) factors in their strategies to manage risks and ensure long-term stability (World Bank, 2022). The issue is a piece of a larger trend we are seeing in international business and finance which is the rise of sustainability as the preeminent issue. Across the globe we have seen the introduction of green bonds, climate finance products and sustainability linked lending (Climate Bonds Initiative, 2023) which we use to see large sums directed at green projects and also which put pressure on companies to perform better for the environment. There is an increasing trend of sustainable financing globally.

Banks play significant role in developing and implementing green finance initiatives. The banks act as intermediaries channelizing funds to various sectors that are contributing to growth and development of the economy. Banks are now implementing green initiatives through green financing, digital transformation of services, energy efficient workplace etc. (Kumar et al., 2019). Incorporating environment, social and governance (ESG) criteria in banking increases transparency and enhances interests of all stakeholders. Green finance is critical for growth hungry Indian economy which is witnessing rapid growth coupled with environmental degradation. Indian banks have started to see the value of sustainable practices and are beginning to use green finance. Large banks are making efforts in promoting green finance compared to smaller banks. Digital banking and online transactions are adopted by banks because it is easier to use and manage still green finance products need to be developed at large scale. Various regulatory bodies have taken steps to introduce rules that support sustainable finance through the adoption of ESG practices by banks (Securities and Exchange Board of India, 2023). There are still some problems that affect the implementation process. The major issue which exists is the lack of technical skills among the bank employees. Another problem is that high costs of implementation, sustainable projects, and climate related risks analysis. In many cases, the banks have limited environmental information. The another problem that arises is the low awareness among customers for

green financial products and services. Banks are introducing various green finance products, the impact of these products is based on customer acceptance and use. Because consumer awareness is low it is difficult for green financial products to expand in India. Considering the opportunities and the current problems, there is a need to study the importance of green finance for promoting sustainable banking in India. This study aims to help policymakers, commercial and development banks and academics to upgrade the existing green finance and to foster sustainability in the Indian banking system.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Green finance play an important role in sustainable development as it promotes green finance investments. In India, green finance should be clearly explained and properly implemented (Ghosh & Singh, 2020). Banks worldwide are adopting environmental, social, and governance (ESG) factors in their decision-making process which shows their efforts to maintain clear practices and reduce risks, which is essential for maintaining their reputation. Similarly, lack of knowledge about ESG factors and poor planning stop banks from adopting them (Bhatia & Tuli, 2021). On the other hand, the adoption of green banking such as paperless banking, digital payments, and energy savings is helping improve sustainability and efficiency of banking operations (Kumar et al., 2019). Also, government support is important for encouraging financial institutions to adopt green banking practices (Sharma & Gupta, 2022). The latest changes in green finance have focused on climate risk control, green loans, and sustainable financing through advancements in technology (Yameen et al., 2024). The importance of green banking has been growing recently, not only from an environmental aspect but also to improve long-term performance (UNEP, 2021). The importance of green investment is growing in India because of the support from governments and investors (Joshi & Patwari, 2025). ESG factors are becoming important in investment decision. Many researchers have carried out research on green finance related with sustainable developmet, ESG investments, and climate-related financial risks (Mudalige, 2023). Banks are adopting sustainable activities such as digital banking services, online transactions, and green finance activities (Reserve Bank of India, 2022). Green finance has become more important in many developing countries, but its adoption has not been very uniform because of the lack of clear policy guidelines (Rahman et al., 2022). Green finance brings some advantages which include better risk management for banks, among other things (Mohanty et al., 2023). The introduction of green bonds is an important component of finance used in sustainable projects despite the low adoption rates in India (Climate Bonds Initiative, 2023).. In order to attain sustainability goals and cut down carbon emissions, it is vital to invest in renewable energy projects (World Bank, 2022). There has been a rise in transparency in reporting of ESG in organizations through sustainability reporting (SEBI, 2023).

Research Gaps

Though substantial work has been undertaken by academics and practitioners on green finance and sustainable banking, still there are some lacunae that need to be bridged. Most of the research studies in the area of green and sustainable banking are based on conventional paradigms and primarily based on secondary data and very little efforts are made to undertake primary data on actual practices of banks and banking professionals. Except a few studies in this emerging area, most of the studies are general in nature and do not offer evidence of how green finance tools are being used in Indian context. In the absence of a uniform taxonomy of green, different banks are expected to use the terms differently. There is a general perception that green finance adoption is also constrained by low levels of awareness, on part of banking professionals and banking institutions about opportunities and challenges and inaccessibility of technical skills, in terms of assessing, pricing, structuring, monitoring and enforcement for green and sustainable finance. This paper tries to fill this gap by conducting the study based on primary data from banking professionals.

Purpose of the Study

The main goal of this research is to study how green finance affects the sustainability of Indian banks. The research also aims to assess bankers' views on green finance and its impact on reducing environmental risks, improving profitability, and enhancing banks image in India. This paper highlights some of the challenges faced in implementing green finance in the Indian banking industry. It will also examine the relationship between awareness of green finance and perceptions of sustainable banking using quantitative methods.

RESEARCH OBJECTIVES

1. To assess the level of technical awareness and conceptual understanding of green finance among banking professionals in India.
2. To evaluate the effect of green finance on mitigating environmental risks and enhancing the long-term profitability and corporate reputation of banks.
3. To study the effect of regulatory measures and government intervention in promoting green finance.
4. To identify the critical operational barriers and assess current customer demand for green finance in the Indian market.

HYPOTHESES OF THE STUDY

Hypothesis 1

H₀₁: There is no significant relationship between technical awareness, regulatory support, and the use of green finance techniques within the banking sector..

H₁₁: There is a significant relationship between technical awareness, regulatory support, and the use of green finance techniques within the banking sector.

Hypothesis 2

H₀₂: There is no effect of green finance on environmental risk management, profitability, and corporate reputation of banks.

H₁₂: Green finance affects environmental risk management, bank profitability, and reputation.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Research Design

The present study is an attempt to understand the determinants and implications of Green Finance. This study is based on both analytical and descriptive research design. In descriptive study, attempts have been made to gather information regarding level of awareness, perception, customer demand and problems faced by the banks related to Green Finance. In analytical study, attempts have been made to test the awareness and perceptions by employing statistical methods like Chi-square test and correlation.

SOURCES OF DATA

Data sources – The research used both primary and secondary data sources.

Primary Data

Since purposive sampling is directly related to the data being collected, primary data will be collected using questionnaires as well as interviews of experts working in banks offering green finance services. This study aims to measure the perception and mental status of green financial products such as green bonds and renewable energy financing.

Secondary Data

The secondary data is based on reports of RBI, SEBI, Ministry of Finance and international sources & journals. Secondary data provides information about various policies, regulations, current trends, and the general adoption of sustainable banking practices in India.

Sample design

Purposive sampling was adopted in this research because the participants selected were aware of green finance and sustainable banking. The bank employees were selected to be the respondents

because they play a major role in decision making regarding finances as well as in implementing sustainability policies in banks. Total 112 respondents who participate in this research.

VARIABLES IN THE STUDY

Independent Variable:

The independent variables included in this study consist of technical skills, government regulations, operational issues, and the customers' demand for eco-friendly banking products.

Dependent Variables:

The dependent variables are the decrease in environmental threats, profitability, and enhancement in the reputation of the bank, since these are affected by green finance.

Control Variables:

The control variables in this study are the nature and the size of the bank.

Tools Used for data analysis

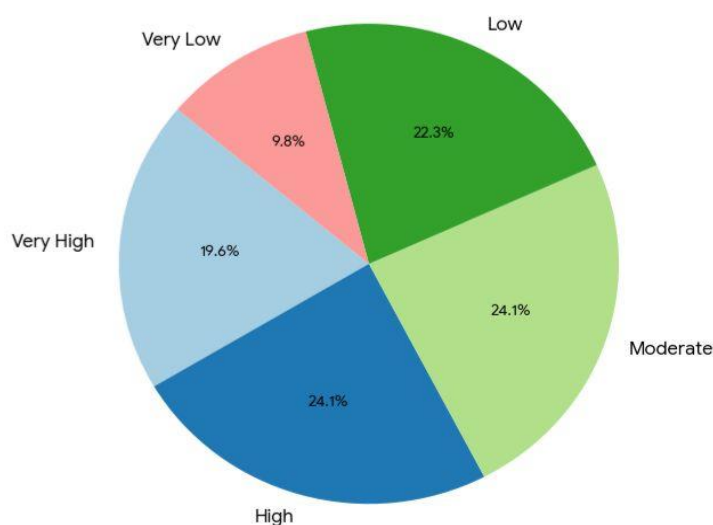
The study uses descriptive statistical tools to analyze the data. Percentage and frequency distribution methods are utilized to arrange and present the data clearly in tables. Responses are collected through the use of questionnaires having five-point Likert scales, which helps measure the opinions of the respondents. To find out whether there is the relationship between green finance practices and sustainable banking, the Chi-square test is applied to check whether or not there is a significant difference in the responses. Correlation analysis was used to measure the strength of association between the two variables, such as awareness of green finance and perception of sustainable banking. The use of descriptive and inferential statistics provides a systematic way to analyze the collected data.

DATA ANALYSIS AND INTERPRETATION

Table 1. Awareness of Green Finance

Awareness Level	Respondents	Percentage
Very High	22	19.6%
High	27	24.1%

Moderate	27	24.1%
Low	25	22.3%
Very Low	11	9.8%
Total	112	100%



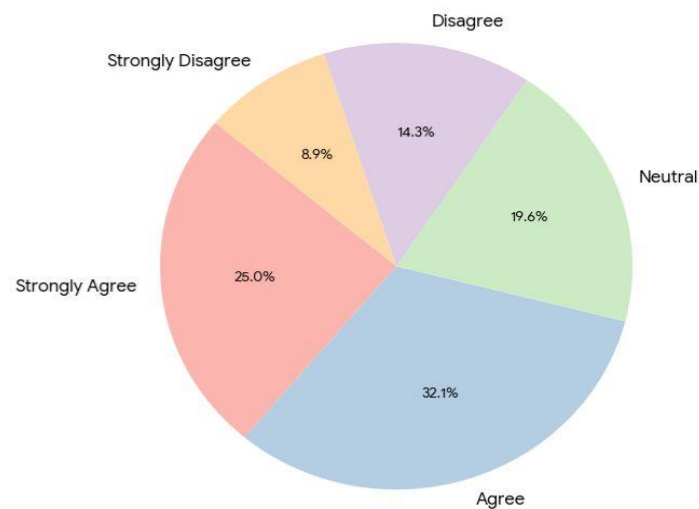
Interpretation:

The data shows that most respondents have some awareness of green finance, suggesting that sustainable banking practices are moderately understood in the industry. However, a significant number still have low awareness, which means more efforts are needed to improve understanding. This reflects a growing but uneven trend in environmentally conscious banking.

Table 2. Green Finance reduces Environmental Risk

Response	Respondents	Percentage
Strongly Agree	28	25.0%

Agree	36	32.1%
Neutral	22	19.6%
Disagree	16	14.3%
Strongly Disagree	10	8.9%
Total	112	100%



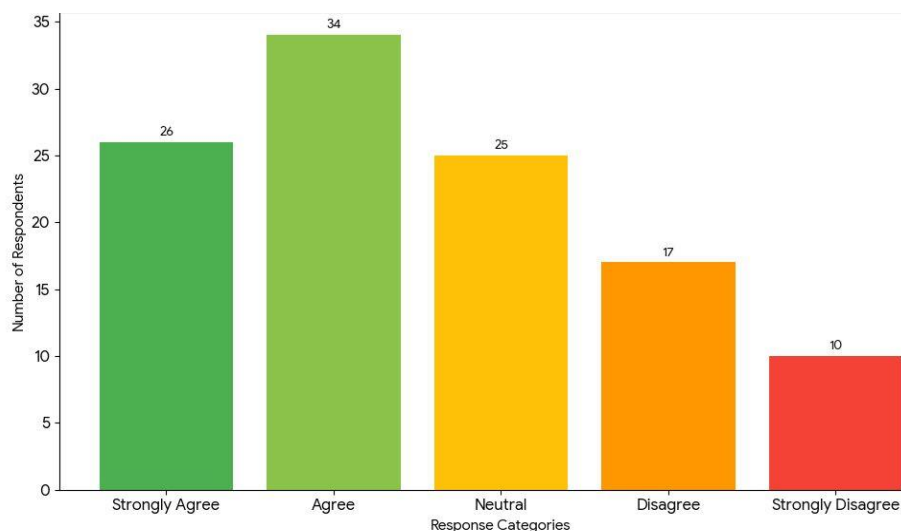
Interpretation:

A majority of participants agree that green finance can help reduce environmental risks. However, the presence of neutral and negative responses suggests that not all respondents are fully convinced about its effectiveness.

Table 3. Green Finance improves Profitability

Response	Respondents	Percentage
Strongly Agree	26	23.2%
Agree	34	30.4%
Neutral	25	22.3%
Disagree	17	15.2%

Strongly Disagree	10	8.9%
Total	112	100%



Interpretation:

A substantial proportion of respondents believe that green finance enhances banks' profitability. Nevertheless, a notable segment remains neutral or disagrees, indicating that the financial benefits of green finance are not universally recognized.

Table 4. Green Finance improves Reputation

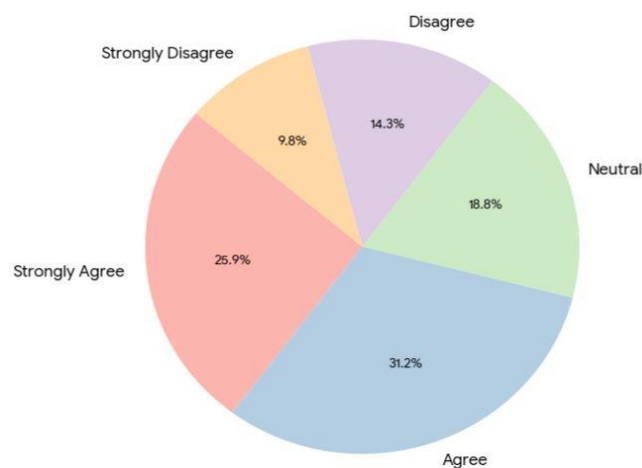
Response	Respondents	Percentage
Strongly Agree	35	31.3%
Agree	33	29.5%
Neutral	20	17.9%
Disagree	14	12.5%
Strongly Disagree	10	8.9%
Total	112	100%

Interpretation:

A majority of participants believe that green finance improves banks' reputation. This suggests that sustainable practices are seen as beneficial for brand image, although some respondents remain uncertain or disagree.

Table 5 : RBI Guidelines Support Green Finance

Response	Respondents	Percentage
Strongly Agree	29	25.9%
Agree	35	31.2%
Neutral	21	18.8%
Disagree	16	14.3%
Strongly Disagree	11	9.8%
Total	112	100%

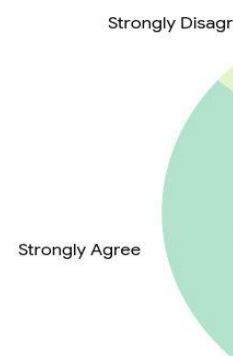


Interpretation:

A majority of participants agree that RBI regulations support green finance. However, a notable proportion remains neutral or disagrees, indicating that regulatory support is recognized but not strongly perceived by all participants.

Table 6: Government Initiatives Encourage Green Finance

Response	Respondents	Percentage
Strongly Agree	31	27.7%
Agree	34	30.4%
Neutral	22	19.6%
Disagree	15	13.4%
Strongly Disagree	10	8.9%
Total	112	100%

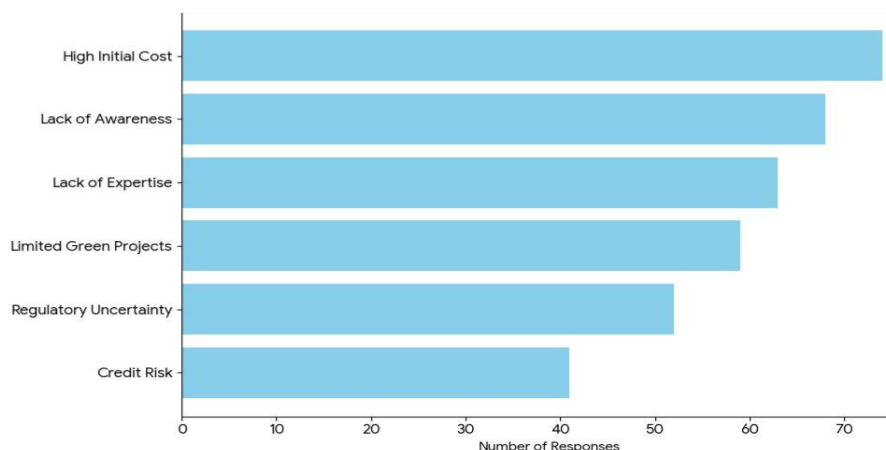


Interpretation:

Most participants agreed that the government initiatives encourage green finance. However, here are a few respondents who seem to be neutral or disagree with this view.

Table 7: Challenges in Green Finance (Multiple Responses)

Challenges	Responses
Lack of Awareness	68
High Initial Cost	74
Limited Green Projects	69
Regulatory Uncertainty	52
Lack of Expertise	63
Credit Risk	41

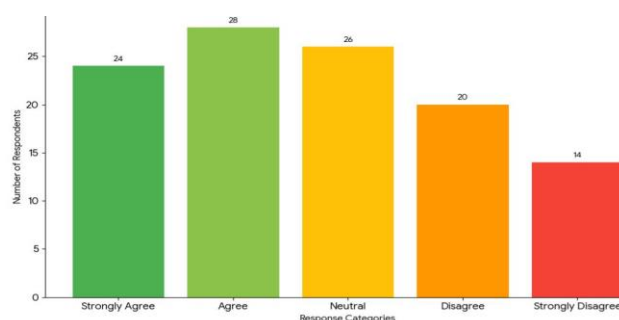


Interpretation:

Key problems include high cost, lack of awareness, and lack of expertise. The problems indicate that financial, informational, and organizational constraints still hinder the successful application of green financing.

Table 8 : Low Customer Demand for Green Finance

Response	Respondents	Percentage
Strongly Agree	24	21.4%
Agree	28	25.0%
Neutral	26	23.2%
Disagree	20	17.9%
Strongly Disagree	14	12.5%
Total	112	100%

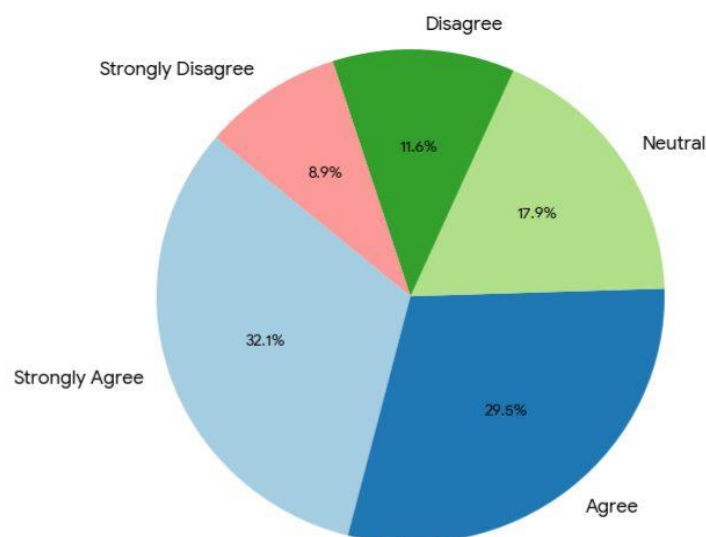


Interpretation:

The findings show that customer demand for green finance is relatively low. More than 45% respondents believe that customer demand is low for green finance.

Table 9: Future Importance of Green Finance

Response	Respondents	Percentage
Strongly Agree	36	32.1%
Agree	33	29.5%
Neutral	20	17.9%
Disagree	13	11.6%
Strongly Disagree	10	8.9%
Total	112	100%



Interpretation:

Most respondents believe that green finance will be important in the future. This shows strong confidence in its contribution to sustainable banking practices.

Chi-square test

This is a test that is conducted in order to establish the presence of any form of significant relationship that exists between two different variables. This will be conducted to determine the relationship between Level of Technical Awareness and Perception of Green Finance in Sustainable Banking.

Objective

To test whether a higher level of technical awareness among banking professionals leads to a more positive perception of the role of green finance.

Variables Used

Variable 1: Technical Awareness Level (High / Low)

Variable 2: Perception of Green Finance (Positive / Neutral & Negative)

Contingency Table (Observed Value)

Awareness level/ Perception	Positive	Neutral/ Negative	Total
High Awareness	42	7	49
Low Awareness	26	37	63
Total	68	44	112

Expected Values Formula

$$E = (\text{Row Total} \times \text{Column Total}) / \text{Grand Total}$$

Expected Value Table

Awareness/ Perception	Positive	Neutral/ Negative	Total
High Awareness	29.75	19.25	49
Low Awareness	38.25	24.75	63
Total	68	44	112

Chi-square formula

$$X^2 = \sum (O - E)^2 / E$$

Degree of freedom

$$Df = (r - 1) \times (c - 1) = (2 - 1) \times (2 - 1) = 1$$

Level of significance

The test is conducted at 5% level of significance ($\alpha = 0.05$)

Critical value

By referring to the chi square distribution table, the critical value for $df = 1$ at 0.05 significance is 3.841.

Statistical Proof

Analysis: From the calculation done statistically, the result was 21.0 for the Chi-Square. This figure denotes the variation between the values obtained and what should have been obtained if there were no association between the variables.

Interpretation

The calculated Chi-Square value (21.0) is significantly higher than the critical table value (3.841). In statistical terms, the p-value is less than 0.05, the result is considered "statistically significant."

Decision

Since the calculated value falls into the rejection region ($21.0 > 3.841$), we Reject the Null Hypothesis (H_{01}) and Accept the Alternative Hypothesis (H_{11}).

Correlation Analysis

The correlation analysis method is a technique that is used to determine the association between two variables. In this research, the correlation analysis will be used with the application of Pearson's Correlation Coefficient (r), where the variables are the level of awareness of green finance and the perception of environmental risk reduction.

Objective

To determine whether an increase in technical awareness among banking professionals corresponds with stronger agreement that green finance effectively reduces environmental risks.

Variables Used

Variable 1 (X): Awareness Level

Variable 2 (Y): Environmental Risk Reduction

Correlation formula

$$r = [\sum XY - (\sum X)(\sum Y)] / \sqrt{[\sum X^2 - (\sum X)^2][\sum Y^2 - (\sum Y)^2]}$$

Where:

N: Total number of respondents (112).

ΣXY : Sum of the product of Awareness scores and Risk Reduction scores.

ΣX : Sum of all Awareness scores.

ΣY : Sum of all Risk Reduction scores.

ΣX^2 : Sum of squared Awareness scores.

ΣY^2 : Sum of squared Risk Reduction scores.

Statistical Proof

The correlation was calculated using the paired responses from the 112 banking professionals regarding their awareness and their views on risk reduction. The statistical results are:

Pearson Correlation Coefficient (r): 0.926

P-value: < 0.001

Interpretation

The calculated Pearson's r value of 0.926 shows a strong positive correlation. The high probability value suggests that banking professionals are more likely to view green finance as a means of mitigating environmental risks. The very low p-value confirms that this relationship is not by chance.

Decision

Since the correlation coefficient is near +1 and the p-value is below 0.05, The statistical results show that there is a positive relationship. This supports the rejection of the null hypothesis and underscores the direct link between technical knowledge and professional belief in the environmental efficacy of green banking.

Findings

The study finds that banking professionals have moderate to high awareness of green finance and generally see it as positive for sustainable banking. It is evident that many of those who responded are convinced that green financing is instrumental in the reduction of environmental risks, increase in profits, and improving reputation among the banks. However, on the other side, there is little demand for these kinds of financial products by customers due to ignorance. The main problems include costly establishment, ignorance, skills, and investment in green projects. Ignorance is critical in terms of reducing risks.

Discussion

The concept of sustainable banking is gaining popularity because the practice of green financing is getting more popular among bankers in India. All those who work in the banking industry have adequate information about sustainable banking. Positive responses about environmental risk reduction, profitability, and reputation show that green finance is seen as a good strategy for long-term success. The study also shows that regulatory frameworks and government initiatives help promote green finance, but not everyone feels their impact equally. Some of the issues include high cost to start, lack of technological know-how, limited green initiatives, and lack of consumer awareness, which continue to hinder the adoption of green finance. The results indicate the importance of creating awareness among consumers for increased use of green finance. The connection between awareness and decreased risk of environmental problems implies that green finance can develop more when awareness increases. Green financing has great prospects for promoting sustainability within the banking sector in India, but this can be achieved by overcoming certain issues.

Suggestion & Recommendation

Awareness about green finance needs to be created among bank employees and consumers. The technical capabilities of banks must be enhanced in order to successfully introduce green financial products. Regulatory authorities must make it easier for banks to engage in green financing projects. Financial support and subsidies can help lower the high initial costs of green finance. Banks should also promote green financial products to boost customer demand and participation. Better access to environmental data and improved risk assessment tools can help banks make informed decisions. Strong cooperation between banks, the government, and other organizations is needed for green finance to succeed in India.

Conclusion

Green finance is an important tool for promoting sustainable banking in India. Most of the banking professionals had positive view towards green finance because they believe that it helps to manage environmental risks and increase profit. Still there are some issues, such as lack of awareness among customers, lack of knowledge, high cost, and scarcity of green projects, limits its adoption.

Limitations

The first drawback is that the sample size used in the research is small and it does not represent the whole banking industry in India. The second limitation is that the results are based on personal opinions of people within the banking industry and it may be biased.

Scope for future research

The future scope of this research includes the possibility of enlarging the scope to include a wider and more diversified sample from other parts of the world and various categories of banks. Future research may focus on multiple areas, including a comparison of green finance programs between different countries and between public sector banks and private banks. Also need to study deeply how green finance affect risk management.

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RESEARCH INSTRUMENTS

The questionnaire uses closed-ended questions, including multiple-choice and Likert-scale items ranging from strongly agree to strongly disagree. The format includes:

- Demographics (bank type, designation, experience, department)
- Consciousness about green finance
- Green finance product portfolio
- Perspective-based questions on a 5-point Likert scale
- Challenges faced during implementation (more than one answer possible)
- Recommendations for improvement (open-ended)

Annexure-1

1. Name of the Bank:

☐ Public Sector

☐ Private Sector

- ☐ Foreign Bank
- ☐ Regional Rural Bank
- ☐ Co-operative Bank

2. Designation:

- ☐ Officer
- ☐ Manager
- ☐ Senior Manager
- ☐ Other (Specify): _____

3. Years of Experience in Banking:

- ☐ Less than 5 years
- ☐ 5–10 years
- ☐ 10–20 years
- ☐ Above 20 years

4. Department:

- ☐ Retail Banking
- ☐ Corporate Banking
- ☐ Credit
- ☐ Risk Management
- ☐ Others: _____

5. Are you aware of the concept of Green Finance?

☐ Yes

☐ No

6. How would you rate your understanding of Green Finance?

☐ Very Low

☐ Low

☐ Moderate

☐ High

☐ Very High

7. Which of the following green finance products are offered by your bank?

☐ Green Loans

☐ Green Bonds

☐ Renewable Energy Financing

☐ ESG-linked Loans

☐ Not Sure

8. Source of your knowledge about Green Finance:

☐ RBI Guidelines

☐ Bank Training Programs

☐ Professional Courses

☐ Media / Reports

☐ Others: _____

9. Green finance helps banks in achieving sustainable banking objectives.

- ☐ Strongly Agree
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Strongly Disagree

10. Green finance initiatives reduce environmental risks in banking operations.

- ☐ Strongly Agree
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Strongly Disagree

11. Adoption of green finance improves the long-term profitability of banks.

- ☐ Strongly Agree
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Strongly Disagree

12. Green finance contributes to better brand image and reputation of banks.

- ☐ Strongly Agree

- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Strongly Disagree

13. RBI guidelines are supportive in promoting green finance in India.

- ☐ Strongly Agree
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Strongly Disagree

14. Government initiatives (such as renewable energy policies) encourage banks to adopt green finance.

- ☐ Strongly Agree
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Strongly Disagree

15. Current regulatory framework is sufficient for green banking practices.

- ☐ Strongly Agree
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

☐ Strongly Disagree

16. What are the major challenges in implementing green finance? (Multiple answers allowed)

☐ Lack of awareness

☐ High initial cost

☐ Limited green projects

☐ Regulatory uncertainty

☐ Credit risk

☐ Lack of expertise

17. Customers show low demand for green finance products.

☐ Strongly Agree

☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

☐ Strongly Disagree

18. Green finance will play a crucial role in the future of Indian banking.

☐ Strongly Agree

☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

☐ Strongly Disagree

19. Banks should increase training programs on green finance for employees.

☐ Strongly Agree

☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

☐ Strongly Disagree

20. What measures can improve adoption of green finance in banks?